

CALCULUS DONE RIGHT

FIRST EDITION

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PREFACE TO THE FIRST EDITION

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Precalculus

SECTION 1

Functions

SUBSECTION 1.1

Function basics

Before we start on the calculus topics, this part of the book will acquaint you with the mathematics you would need to understand in order to read this book. If you are familiar with these topics, you may skip to the Part II on Calculus I. For the rest of you, the pace of this part will be very fast, it is recommended that you read up on concepts you do understand very well. We will start with the idea of a *function*. By now, I am sure that many of you may have seen equations like these:

$$x^2 - 5x + 6 = 0 \quad (1.1)$$

$$\sin(x) = 0.5, 0 \leq x \leq \frac{\pi}{2} \quad (1.2)$$

$$y = mx + c \quad (1.3)$$

Out of the three equations, notice that 1.3 is special. There is not some fixed x values that you must plug in. Instead, the y value varies with the x value. Given a x value, the equation "produces" a y value. This brings us to the idea of a function. A function is simply something that takes in a value, and "produces" another value based on the input. You may have come across functions before, such as the trigonometric functions like $\sin$ and $\cos$. The value of $\sin(x)$ varies with different values of x . Of course, it is time for me to give you the definition of a function.

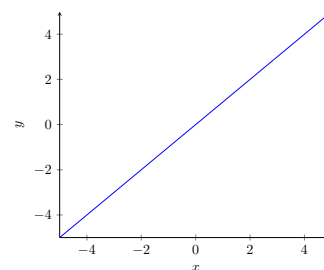


Figure 1. Graph of $y=x$.

Definition 1 A function f is a mathematical object that assigns its inputs, or *domain*, to its outputs, or *range*. The notation $f : A \rightarrow B$ means that the function has a domain A and range B . The notation $f(a)$ where $a \in A$ denotes the element of B to which a is assigned to.

Notice that A and B are sets.

Example Here are some examples of functions:

$$f(x) = x + 1 \quad (1.4)$$

$$g(x) = \sin(x) \quad (1.5)$$

$$h(x) = x^2 - 5x + 6 \quad (1.6)$$

To evaluate the output of a function, you simply substitute the input to the expression that defines the function. Notice that for 1.4, it is simply the line $y = x + 1$. Each value of $f(x)$ for some $x \in \mathbb{R}$ is just y . Take $x = 1$ for example, $f(1) = 1 + 1 = 2$ and for the line $y = x + 1$, notice the y value here is also 2. The function assigns each x value to $x + 1$. Hence, in this case, $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. For 1.5, the function takes any real x value and maps it to $\sin(x)$. As a result, its domain would be $\mathbb{R}$ and its range would be $[-1, 1]$. Again, it is just like the graph $y = \sin(x)$.

Lastly, the quadratic 1.6 is another real function (i.e. it has a real domain and range). Think about what happens when $h(x) = 0$, what value of x must you plug in to make $h(x) = 0$. Well, isn't it just the roots of the quadratic. Hence, the roots of a function are just the values x such that $h(x) = 0$. In this case, it would be 2 and 3. Thus, $h(2) = h(3) = 0$.

Actually, functions can be more than the usual $f(x) = \text{something}$. Let's say you want to have a function that outputs "1" if the input is rational and "0" if it is not, you can define it as such:

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } x \in \mathbb{Q} \\ 0, & \text{if } x \notin \mathbb{Q} \end{cases} \quad (1.7)$$

Here, $f(\frac{1}{2})$ would be 1 but $f(\sqrt{2})$ would be 0. This is an example of having conditionals in a function. Lastly, functions may take more than one input and produce more than one output, examples include:

$$f(x, y) = x^2 + y^2 \quad (1.8)$$

$$g(t) = (\cos(t), \sin(t)) \quad (1.9)$$

1.8 is an example of a *multivariate* function, in other words, it takes in multiple inputs. If $x = 2$ and $y = 2$, then $f(2, 2) = 8$. On the other hand, 1.9 does not have a single output. Instead, it has a tuple as its output. Evaluating it at $t = \pi$, notice that the output is $(-1, 0)$. What is interesting is that if you trace out its outputs on a plane for all $t \in \mathbb{R}$, you will get:

This is actually the famous Dirichlet function that shatters certain intuitions on functions and will be discussed in later chapters.

As you will see in Part IV of the book, this is the parametric equation of a circle.

A tuple is basically a set where order matters. You can treat it as if it is a coordinate.

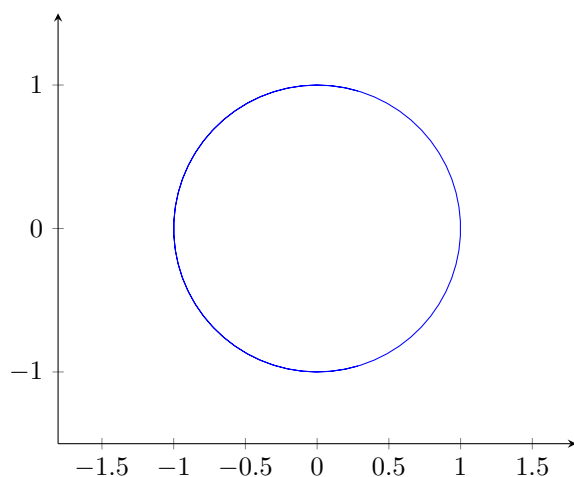


Figure 2. Plot of 1.9 for all $t \in \mathbb{R}$

Functions are the building blocks of mathematics, and this book will deal extensively with it. Therefore, it is paramount that you get the basics right. Try the following exercise:

Exercise

1. Given that $x = 2$ and $y = \pi$, evaluate $f(x)$ for:

(a) $f(x) = x^3 + 1$

(b) $f(x) = 2^x$

$$(c) f(x) = \begin{cases} x^4 + 1 & \text{if } x < 2 \\ 3^x & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

$$(d) f(x, y) = \frac{\sin(y)}{x}$$

2. Given the following functions, write down $f : A \rightarrow B$ where A is the domain and B is the range (do not consider complex inputs and outputs):

$$(a) f(x) = x$$

$$(b) f(x) = \frac{1}{x}$$

$$(c) f(x) = \sqrt{x}$$

3. Find the root(s) of the following functions:

$$(a) f(x) = x^2$$

$$(b) f(x) = 2^x - 1$$

$$(c) f(x) = \sin(x)$$

*This function has a special name, the **identity** function. Notice how its input and output are the same.*

Solution

1. (a) 9
(b) 4
(c) 9
(d) 0
2. (a) $f : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$
(b) $f : \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\} \rightarrow \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$ (Note the function is not defined at $x = 0$)
(c) $f : \mathbb{R}_0^+ \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_0^+$ (Square root not defined for negative numbers)
3. (a) 0
(b) 1
(c) $n\pi, \forall n \in \mathbb{Z}$

SUBSECTION 1.2

Function composition and inverses

In this chapter, we will look at composition of functions and inverse functions. You can use the normal arithmetic operations on functions like how you would to numbers:

Example If $x = 2$ and $f(x) = x^2 + 4$:

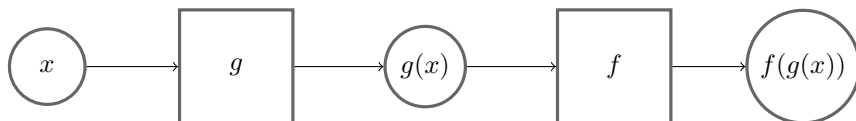
$$f(x) + f(x) = 2^2 + 4 + 2^2 + 4 = 16$$

$$\frac{f(x)}{2} = \frac{2^2 + 4}{2} = 4$$

What is more interesting, perhaps, is taking the *output* of a function and use it as the *input* to another function. You may also think of it as "piping" one function into another. This is called *function composition*.

Another notation for composing functions together (which we will not really use) is as such:

$$f(g(x)) = (f \circ g)(x)$$



Note that the rectangles are functions and circles are values.

Figure 3. Visual representation of function composition.

When you compose the same function n -times, the notation for it is:

$$f^n(x) = \underbrace{f(f(\dots f(x)))}_{n\text{-times}}$$

However, this does not apply to trigonometric functions. $\sin^2(x)$ is $\sin(x) \times \sin(x)$ instead of $\sin(\sin(x))$ and $\sin^{-1}(x)$ is $\arcsin(x)$.

Example Here are some examples of composing functions together: If $x = 3$ and $f(x) = \pi x$, $g(x) = \sin(x) + 1$:

$$g(f(x)) = \sin(\pi \times 3) + 1 = 1 \quad (1.10)$$

$$f^3(x) = \pi^3 x \quad (1.11)$$

There is nothing much here, really, just evaluate the function from the innermost function to the outermost.

Theorem 1 Given functions $f : X \rightarrow Y$, $g : Y \rightarrow Z$ and $h : Z \rightarrow W$, prove that the composition of the three functions is *associative*, in other words:

$$h \circ (g \circ f) = (h \circ g) \circ f$$

PROOF Let $x \in X$, we have:

$$h \circ (g \circ f(x)) = h(g \circ f(x)) = h(g(f(x))) = h \circ g(f(x)) = (h \circ g)f(x)$$

This proves the associativity of function composition.

QED

Remark This is just a fun little exercise for the reader and ultimately is not that important to the entire book, just a good identity to keep in the back of your mind.

Next, we will delve into inverse functions. Let us start with one I believe you may have seen before, look at the following figure:

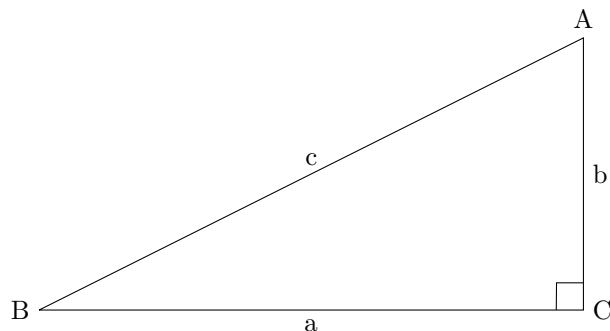


Figure 4. Figure of right triangle ABC.

If I ask you what is $\arcsin(B)$, you may say it is $\frac{b}{c}$. But, what is $\arcsin(\sin(B))$, well, that is just B , isn't it. Hence, the $\arcsin$ sort of "cancels" the $\sin$. We call $\arcsin$ the *inverse function* or just inverse of $\sin$. Generally, given a function f , f^{-1} denotes the inverse function such that $f^{-1}(f(x)) = x$. Notice that if we apply both of the functions

together, we get the identity function, that is:

$$f \circ f^{-1} = id_x \text{ where } id_x \text{ is the identity function} \quad (1.12) \quad \text{The identity function is just } f(x) = x$$

To find the inverse function of a function f , we have to find the function that maps the outputs of the f back to its inputs. To solve algebraically, we set $f(x)$ for some arbitrary x to y , and make x the subject of the equation.

Example Given that $f(x) = \frac{x+7}{3}$:

$$\begin{aligned} f(x) &= y \\ \frac{x+7}{3} &= y \\ x+7 &= 3y \\ x &= 3y-7 \end{aligned}$$

Hence, the inverse function is $f^{-1}(x) = 3y-7$.

Exercise 1. Given $f(x) = \frac{x^2+3}{2}$ and $g(x) = \tan(x) + 1$, evaluate:

- (a) $f(g(\frac{\pi}{4}))$
- (b) $f^3(1)$
- (c) $f(g(\arcsin(0)))$

2. Given that $h(x) = (x-7)^2$, $x \geq 7$, find the inverse of h .

3. Hence, evaluate:

- (a) $h^{-1}(1)$
- (b) $h(h^{-1}(69))$

Solution

- 1. (a) $\frac{7}{2}$
- (b) $\frac{61}{8}$
- (c) 2